DESIGN SYSTEM

Swissintell.

Foundational tokens, components and rules for the Swissintell website. Built on WordPress. Based on the homepage redesign mockup.

VERSION	SCOPE	DATE
1.0	**Homepage foundations**	**April 2026**

01 · PRINCIPLES

How this system thinks

Four principles guide every decision in the Swissintell design system. They exist so the site reads as Swiss, institutional and credible — without being cold or bureaucratic.

PRINCIPLE 01

Institutional, not corporate

Swissintell is a nonprofit with 18+ years of history. The visual tone is confident and serious, not trying to look like a startup or a bank. Generous whitespace, restrained color, strong typography.

PRINCIPLE 02

Red earns its weight

Red is the brand accent — not a background color. It signals action (CTAs), brand (logo, labels) or key emphasis. If everything is red, nothing is. Used sparingly, it directs the eye.

PRINCIPLE 03

Dark for authority, light for content

Navy sections (hero, members, footer) project institutional weight. Light sections carry editorial content (events, press, verticals). Alternation creates rhythm and makes both feel intentional.

PRINCIPLE 04

Motion is a whisper

Transitions are fast (150–250ms) and use a single easing curve. No bouncing, no parallax, no carousels. Motion acknowledges interaction — it never performs.

02 · COLOR

Color tokens

A tight palette: one brand red, one institutional navy scale, a clean neutral range, and four tag colors for content verticals.

Brand

Brand Red
`--color-brand-red`
`#E01A27`

Red Hover
`--color-brand-red-hover`
`#B8101C`

Red Soft (10%)
`--color-brand-red-soft`
`#E01A27 · 10%`

Red Border (25%)
`--color-brand-red-border`
`#E01A27 · 25%`

Dark surfaces (institutional)

Navy (primary dark)
`--color-surface-navy`
`#0D1B35`

Navy 2 (elevated)
`--color-surface-navy-2`
`#162040`

Card Dark
`--color-surface-card-dark`
`#131F38`

Border Dark
`--color-border-dark`
`#222F4A`

Light surfaces (editorial)

`transparent`

Page Background
`--color-surface-bg`
`#F8F9FB`

Card / Panel
`--color-surface-card`
`#FFFFFF`

Border Light
`--color-border-light`
`#DDE1E9`

—
`(intentionally blank)`

Text

Text Primary
`--color-text-primary`
`#111827`

Text Secondary
`--color-text-secondary`
`#6B7280`

Text Muted (on dark)
`--color-text-muted`
`#8A96AA`

Text White
`--color-text-white`
`#FFFFFF`

Tag colors (press & content categories)

CYBER

Cyber (red)
`--tag-cyber-*`

GEOPOLITICS

Geopolitics (blue)
`--tag-geo-*`

ECON. INTEL

Economic (gold)
`--tag-econ-*`

TECH & AI

Tech (purple)
`--tag-tech-*`

✓ DO

Use red for CTAs, brand marks, and key emphasis. Use navy for institutional sections (hero, members, footer). Use light neutrals for content-rich editorial sections.

✗ DON'T

Don't stack multiple red elements in a row — it creates visual noise. Don't use tag colors outside their content vertical. Don't introduce new colors not listed here without updating the token file.

03 · TYPOGRAPHY

Type scale

Calibri is the brand typeface, used across the site. The scale is modular and intentional — eight sizes cover every use case in the homepage.

`--font-size-4xl`	**Hero headline**	56px · 800
`--font-size-3xl`	**Section title**	40px · 800
`--font-size-2xl`	**Sub-section heading**	28px · 700
`--font-size-xl`	**Card title / small heading**	22px · 700
`--font-size-lg`	Lead paragraph / press title	18px · 400
`--font-size-base`	Body text, paragraph content, default UI.	16px · 400
`--font-size-sm`	Small UI text, metadata, buttons, navigation.	14px · 400
`--font-size-xs`	EYEBROW LABEL · TAG · CAPTION	12px · 700

✓ DO

Use the scale as-is. Large headings (3xl, 4xl) get tight letter-spacing (-0.03em). Eyebrow labels are always uppercase with wide tracking (0.14em).

✗ DON'T

Don't create intermediate sizes. Don't use Calibri italics for body text. Don't mix Calibri with other typefaces beyond the documented system fallbacks.

04 · SPACING

Spacing scale

A 4px-based scale. Section vertical rhythm is driven by `--space-20` (80px). Everything else nests inside that.

`--space-1`	4px
`--space-2`	8px
`--space-3`	12px
`--space-4`	16px
`--space-6`	24px
`--space-8`	32px
`--space-12`	48px
`--space-16`	64px
`--space-20`	80px

05 · ELEVATION

Shadows

Five shadow levels. Use the lowest level that reads as elevated against the surface. The red glow is reserved exclusively for primary CTAs on hover.

--shadow-xs	--shadow-sm	--shadow-md	--shadow-lg	--shadow-red-lg

06 · MOTION

Duration & easing

Three durations, two easings. That's the entire motion system. Consistency matters more than variety.

--duration-fast

150ms

Button hover, link color changes, toggle states.

--duration-base

200ms

Card hover, nav underline, backgrounds, most transitions.

--duration-slow

250ms

Larger layout shifts (card elevations, modals opening).

--ease-out

cubic-bezier(0.2, 0.8, 0.2, 1)

Default for entering/appearing elements. Feels responsive.

--ease-in-out

cubic-bezier(0.4, 0, 0.2, 1)

State changes where start and end are both visible (hover reversals).

Rule

Avoid

No bouncing, spring, or elastic easings. No auto-scrolling carousels. No parallax.

Buttons

Three button styles. One primary per section, ghost variants for secondary actions.

PRIMARY · MAIN CTAS

`.btn-primary`

Become a Member | Subscribe | Register now →

GHOST (DARK) · SECONDARY ACTIONS ON DARK BACKGROUNDS

`.btn-ghost · use inside .surface-dark or .surface-gradient-dark`

Upcoming Events | Members Login

GHOST (LIGHT) · SECONDARY ACTIONS ON LIGHT BACKGROUNDS

`.btn-ghost-light · use inside .surface-light or .surface-white`

View all events → | View all →

✓ DO

Use one primary button per section. Pair it with a ghost if a secondary action exists. Keep labels concise (2–4

✗ DON'T

Don't place two primary buttons adjacent — it creates competing CTAs. Don't invent new button colors or

words).

sizes.

Labels & tags

Small identifiers that classify content without adding noise.

EYEBROW LABEL · SITS ABOVE SECTION TITLES

`.label`

AGENDA

Upcoming Events

PRESS TAGS · ONE PER CONTENT VERTICAL

`.press-tag + .tag-geo / .tag-econ / .tag-tech`

CYBER GEOPOLITICS ECON. INTEL TECH & AI

PRICE BADGE (PILL) · MEMBERS AREA

`.price-badge`

CHF 150 / year Featured

09 · COMPONENTS · CARDS

Cards

Three card patterns cover every content block on the homepage. Cards are structural — the grid that contains them defines the rhythm.

EVENT CARD · LIGHT SURFACE, IMAGE HEADER, BODY

`.card-event`

TUE 20 MAY · 17:00

Cybersecurity & Critical Infrastructure

Expert roundtable on threats to Swiss digital infrastructure.

VERTICAL CARD · ICON + LABEL, FITS IN A GRID

`.card-vertical + .icon-tile`

Cybersecurity
142 articles

Geopolitics
218 articles

Economic Intel
183 articles

Technology & AI
95 articles

RESOURCE CARD · PRIVATE MEMBERS AREA, DARK SURFACE

`.card-resource · inside .panel-elevated`

Swissintell Annual Report 2025

PDF · 28 pages · Members only

10 · PATTERNS

Layout patterns

How sections are composed. Every homepage section follows one of these three patterns.

PATTERN A

Section header (content-centric)

Eyebrow label (red, uppercase) → h2 title → lead paragraph. Optional "view all" link aligned right. Used in Events, Verticals, Press Review.

PATTERN B

Split section (50/50)

Text column + visual column, 50/50 on desktop, stacked on mobile. Used in Members Area (text + resource card) and Newsletter (text + form).

PATTERN C

Hero + stats bar

Full-width dark hero section, followed by a dark stats bar (4 metrics, dividers between). Used once, at the top of the homepage only.

RULE

Rhythm by alternation

Dark → Light → White → Dark → Light → Dark. Never stack two dark or two white sections in a row. This alternation creates visual rhythm.

11 · USAGE

How to use these files

Two CSS files. Import them in order. Build on top of the component layer — never overwrite tokens inline.

```
/* In your WordPress theme header or main stylesheet */
@import "tokens.css";    /* foundation variables */
@import "components.css"; /* reusable components */
```

✓ DO

Reference every color, size, space and shadow via its token (e.g. `var(--space-8)`). Extend the system by adding new tokens, not overriding values.

✗ DON'T

Don't hardcode hex colors or pixel values in page templates. Don't duplicate components with small variations — consolidate into the system.

Swissintell Design System · v1.0

This is a living document. As the site grows, the system grows with it. Maintained by the design team.